LEVERHULME TRUST

Early Career Fellowships
Application Help Notes 2026

Please consult these help notes when completing the application form. These are also accessible via the Help button on each relevant section of the online application form.

- Applications do not have to be completed in one session – your details can be saved and you can return to the application later.
- Applications must be approved by (i) your head of department and (ii) an administrative officer on behalf of the university, in that order, by the closing date of **4pm on 19 February 2026**.
- It is strongly recommended that you ensure that your host university is aware of the approval process well in advance of submitting your application for institutional approval.
- It is your responsibility to complete your application in time for the host university to process it. The Trust strongly recommends that you submit your application for institutional approval at least five working days before the closing date.
- Please also ensure that you meet the conditions of eligibility and have completed the application form correctly before submitting.
- To submit an application: complete all sections of the form, select Validation to confirm that you have completed the mandatory fields correctly. If there are no errors you can then save and close the application and select the Submit button to submit the application for the two forms of institutional approval. Once the application is submitted it will not be possible for you to edit it unless your head of department or the institutional approver rejects it. However, you will be able to view it.
- It is your responsibility to check the status of your application in the Grants Management System and to ensure that the necessary approvals are provided in time.
- You may submit only one application for an Early Career Fellowship per year. Previously unsuccessful applicants may reapply.
- Candidates who have held a Leverhulme Study Abroad Studentship for postdoctoral research are not eligible to apply for an Early Career Fellowship. Please note, this only applies to the 2019 award schemes onwards.

Applicant details

To amend these details please save and close this application and visit the 'Manage My Details' section. These details will be carried forward to this application form and any subsequent applications you make.

Career details

To amend these details please save and close this application and visit the 'Manage My Details' section. These details will be carried forward to this application form and any subsequent applications you make.

Education details

To amend these details please save and close this application and visit the 'Manage My Details' section. These details will be carried forward to this application form and any subsequent applications you make. Please ensure you include the details of your doctoral degree even if it has not yet been awarded.

Further applicant details

- If you are or have been registered for a doctoral degree **have you submitted your thesis** for viva voce examination: select Yes or No. If Yes enter the date you submitted your doctoral thesis for viva voce examination. If No enter the date you will submit your doctoral thesis for viva voce examination. This must be no later than 19 February 2026.
- If you have not yet submitted your doctoral thesis you will need to provide the email address of your main doctoral supervisor. Your main doctoral supervisor may be contacted to confirm the submission date of your doctoral thesis. **Do not apply if you will not have submitted your thesis by 19 February 2026** – your application will be rejected.
- Those who **submitted their thesis for viva voce examination before 19 February 2022 are not eligible unless they have since had a career break**. You must therefore explain the nature of the career break (e.g. a period of maternity leave, family commitments, illness or other exceptional circumstances). Enter details of the nature and dates of the career break which you believe makes you eligible. Please note, time spent working outside academia does not qualify as a career break. Applicants with a disability who wish to make a case for the extension of the four-year eligibility window may do so using the career break section of the application form.
- **Have you held or do you currently hold postdoctoral positions to pursue your own research project totalling three or more years**: select Yes or No. Please note, this refers to the full duration of the post/s and not the duration completed at the time of application or start of the Fellowship. Do not apply if your answer is Yes – your application will be rejected.
- **Please describe any current and previous postdoctoral positions and outline the nature of your role**: briefly describe your research responsibilities in your current and/or previous postdoctoral positions and give an indication of the amount of time available to you to pursue your own independent research in each position. If you have not yet held a postdoctoral position you can enter "not applicable" or "n/a".

- **Do you currently have a funded/paid position:** select Yes or No. If Yes, enter the date your current funding/position ends.
- **Proposed start date for Fellowship**: enter the date you propose to start the Fellowship. This must be between 1 September 2026 and 1 May 2027 (all Fellowships must begin on the first of a given month within this period). If the take-up date is before the date your current funding ends you will need to complete the following two questions:
    1. **Explain why you wish to take up the Leverhulme Fellowship before your current position/funding has expired:** explain the reasons for intending to start this fellowship before your current funding has finished.
    2. **As you have funding for the next academic year, please explain the reasons for applying in this round:** specify why you are applying in this particular round, despite having already secured a position/funding for the year in which the Leverhulme fellowship must be taken up. Please note that this fellowship cannot be held at the same time or in conjunction with another grant or position.
- **Widening participation statement**: The Leverhulme Trust is committed to increasing the inclusiveness of our grant-making processes, with the aim of achieving greater diversity in our applicants. This is vital to ensure that we have the opportunity to fund the best quality research. The Trust therefore encourages applications from under-represented groups, including (but not limited to) people with disabilities, ethnic minorities (especially Black British), applicants from lower income households, and applicants who began their academic careers as mature students. We recognise that many students and researchers have faced obstacles in their educational journey. Please use this section of the application to describe the obstacles you have faced. There is a limit of 150 words, and the statement is entirely voluntary.
- **Any other matters you wish to bring to the attention of the Committee:** any issues which you feel that the Committee should be aware of which you have not addressed elsewhere in the application.

Research and publications

- **Title of research proposal:** no more than 80 characters including spaces.
- **Fields of study - main area of research**: select **one** field of study which most closely reflects the main area of research of the current application.
- **Fields of study - sub areas of research**: you can select up to two more fields of study which also reflect the area of research of the current application (optional).
- **Abstract:** this account should be given in non-technical terms so as to be easily comprehensible to a non-expert (maximum 100 words).
- **Details of current and past research:** give details of your current and past research experience (maximum 250 words). If this is too extensive to be summarised in 250 words focus on the research most relevant to the current application.
- **Detailed statement of proposed research:** this should include aims, objectives, methodology and outcome (e.g. publication plans). It should enable the Committee and your referees to form an estimate of the scope and importance of your proposal. The methodology should be clear and explicit, comprehensible to a non-expert. Include bibliographic references in full, including page numbers where relevant. Upload either a Word document or PDF (up

to two sides of A4). You must use Arial font size 11, margins no smaller than 2cm and line spacing no smaller than single line. Applications with detailed statements that do not met these specifications will be returned.

- **Major publications:** list your publications (maximum one side of A4) under three main headings; 'In preparation', 'Submitted' and 'Published', as appropriate. Please reference publications in full (i.e. author/s, journal titles, and page numbers) and if publications are in press give a word count for each. If a full list of your publications exceeds one page then include only the publications most relevant to the current application. Upload either a Word document or PDF (up to 1 side of A4). Please use Arial font size 11, margins no smaller than 2cm and line spacing no smaller than single line.

Duration, timing and host university

- **Duration of Fellowship:** the duration is 36 months full-time unless the percentage of time dedicated to the project is less than 100%.
- **Percentage of time to be spent on the Fellowship:** state what percentage of time you would dedicate to the project, for example 50% over 72 months. It is not possible to hold a Fellowship for under 36 months. Please note that you cannot hold the Fellowship part-time and hold another post at the same time. The Trust will support requests to hold the award part-time over a proportionately longer period for health related reasons, disability or childcare commitments. You will then be required to complete three further questions for awards on a part-time basis:
  1. **Reasons why this is appropriate for the range and type of research activities proposed:** explain why a part-time award would be appropriate for the range and type of research activities proposed (maximum 100 words).
  2. **Reasons why this is appropriate for your career development:** explain why a part-time award would be appropriate for your career development (maximum 100 words).
  3. **Personal reasons for holding the fellowship on a part-time basis:** detail the personal reasons why you would like to hold the award at less than 100% of full-time (maximum 100 words).
- **Host University:** type the first three letters of your host university and then select it from the drop-down box.
- **Host Department:** enter the name of your host department.
- **Research relevant to your proposal being carried out in the host department:** details of other research being conducted in the host department which is relevant to your own proposed project (maximum 100 words).
- **Additional reasons for selecting your chosen host department and university:** explain any additional reasons for choosing this particular department and university to host your award (maximum 100 words).
- **If you have not moved institutions in the course of your academic career (i.e. between your undergraduate university and proposed host university), please give the reasons as to why you wish to remain in your current university: e**xplain the academic and/or personal reasons why you wish to remain at the same university (maximum 100 words). If you have moved institutions in the course of your academic career you do not need to answer this question and can enter "not applicable" or "n/a".

Institutional approval details

Please read these details very carefully as they explain the nature of the institutional approval process.

- Click **Add Head of Department** to add the name of the head of department of your host department.
- Enter their surname and click Search.
- Select the correct name.
- If a matching contact is not found, follow the instructions to add a new contact.
- Check the tick box confirming that you wish to include this department head on your application and click Send The Invitation to send the email notifying them of this. They will then receive an email with instructions about how to view your application. You should only add the head of department if you are confident that they will support your application. You should also check that the person selected is the current head of department.
- When you submit the application the head of department will be sent a further email asking them to approve the completed application and provide details about the relevance of your research to the department; the facilities and resources you will have access to; your starting salary; and the source of the matching funding. Your head of department must select Approve/Reject first in order to enter these details. Once the head of department has completed these details they can submit the application for final institutional approval. Only when this final approval has been given will the application be submitted to the Leverhulme Trust.
- Click **Notify Institutional Approver**.
- You may notify your designated institutional approver at any time to allow them to view your application. Check the tick box confirming you wish to notify the institutional approver and click Notify to send the email. They will then receive an email with instructions about how to view the application. You must do this before you submit the completed application form to your head of department.
- **Both forms of approval must be received by 4pm on 19 February 2026** and applicants are urged to submit their applications at least five working days before the closing date to allow both forms of approval to take place in good time. Please note that once you have submitted your application you will not be able to edit it. Please also ensure that your host university is aware of the approval process.

Referees

You are required to nominate three referees. Shortly after your application is submitted to the Trust by the institutional approver an email will be sent to your referees with a link to your application. It is crucial that you enter correct email addresses. You must provide full details for your referees. If they do not have a department or institution, please enter ‘n/a’ in these fields. You must check that they are able and willing to **provide a reference via the online system no later than 12 March 2026.** You can **check receipt of your references in the My Referees section of the Grants Management System**. When nominating referees, please note:

- Only one referee can be from the proposed host university – applications with more than one referee from the host university will be returned.
- We strongly recommend that the referees are not all from the same institution.

- The proposed mentor can be a referee.
- The head of department of your proposed host department cannot be a referee.

Referees will be asked to (a) state in what capacity they know you (b) comment on the proposed research and the extent to which it will make a difference to your field of research, and (c) provide an appraisal of your academic and personal qualities for carrying out the research proposal and how this will contribute to your career development. References are subject to a word limit of 500 words. Please **ensure your referees are aware in advance of the word limit**.

Previous and current applications

- **Previous Leverhulme applications and awards or pending applications to the Trust:** details of any previous or pending applications made to the Trust, and awards held. Please include the year applied or awarded, scheme name and project title.
- **Other awards received in the last 12 months related to this project:** details of awards you and any collaborators have received from other sources for research related to the proposal. Give details of the funding body, nature and amount of funding, year awarded and project title.
- **Applications you have made or intend to make to other bodies related to this research proposal:** if you have or intend to apply elsewhere for funding related to the present application, detail the funding body and type of funding sought. Such applications do not prejudice your application for a Leverhulme award. Please notify the Trust if you are subsequently offered any other awards.
- **Where did you hear about this Leverhulme scheme:** select one of the options.

Research budget

Give an indication of how you propose to use the annual research allocation of £6,000 for each year of the Fellowship to support the research described. Please provide a brief summary of the anticipated budget items and approximate costs. It is not possible to claim more than £6,000 in year one, but any funds not used or claimed can be carried over or claimed in later years (e.g. if you use £5,000 in year one, up to £7,000 will be available in year two). Please note that **research budgets are not approved at the application stage** and if the application is successful you will have the opportunity to revise these details.

Validation

Before submitting your application you must first click Validation to verify that all required fields have been completed. If there are no errors you can then save and close this form and submit your application from the application summary screen.

Once the application is submitted it will not be possible for you to edit it, so please download a copy of the application and proof-read it carefully before submitting it.

Once the application has been submitted it must be approved online in the following order: 1) by your head of department and 2) by the institutional approver of the host university. **Both**

approvals must be completed by 4pm on 19 February 2026. If the head of department and/or the institutional approver returns your application you will be sent an email notifying you of this. You will then have the opportunity to edit the application and re-submit it for the two forms of approval.

Additional guidance notes for heads of department

Please forward the information in this section to the head of department at your host university.

Once the applicant has submitted their application for head of department approval the head of department will receive an email asking them to approve the completed application and provide details about the relevance of the applicant's research to the department, the facilities and resources the applicant will have access to, the applicant's starting salary and year one salary estimate, and the source of the matching funding. Please note, the head of department **must first click Approve/Reject to complete their section of the application**.

Relevance of the research to the department

The head of department will be asked to provide responses (limited to 100 words each) to the following questions:

- Why is your department the best place for the applicant to undertake their research project?
- Why would you like the applicant to be hosted by your department and what are the benefits to your university by acting as their host?
- How will the applicant be mentored by colleagues in your department?
- How might the applicant contribute to teaching and the wider intellectual life of the host department?
- What facilities and relevant resources will the applicant be provided with by the host department? Please note, the host department is expected to provide the candidate with their own computer and dedicated desk and/or laboratory space.

Starting Salary

The head of department is required to confirm the starting salary and spine point agreed with the applicant. Please ensure that the **starting salary has been agreed with the applicant prior to finalising the application**, and that this is in line with the university's salary policy. Please use the current salary rate on the agreed spine point if the rate at the time of commencing the fellowship is not yet known or confirmed.

Year One Salary Estimate (100% of costs)

Please enter the year one figures only without increments or pay awards.

Source of matching funding

The head of department is asked to identify the source of the matching funding for the Fellowship. Please note that the matching funding contributed by the host university must be

drawn from generally available funds and cannot be associated with any other grants received by the university. The host department must secure the matching funding for the applicant before the closing date. Applications that do not meet these conditions are ineligible and will be rejected.